

IN CONTEXT

Mantua under the Gonzagas

Monteverdi's patrons, the Gonzaga family, ruled the city of Mantua for almost 400 years. In the 15th and 16th centuries, their palace was a major center of Renaissance culture, attracting artists such as Andrea Mantegna, who depicted the Gonzagas in the murals of the palace's Camera degli Sposi (1465–1474). Isabella d'Este, married into the family in 1490, was among the most renowned patrons of Renaissance art. When Monteverdi arrived in Mantua in 1591, the court was still at the height of its splendor and prestige, but the 17th century brought rapid decline. Gonzaga rule ended in 1708.



LUDOVICO GONZAGA (LEFT) WITH HIS
FAMILY, FRESCO BY MANTEGNA, c. 1474

The son of an apothecary, Claudio Giovanni Antonio Monteverdi